also picked up information that Bhutto had subtly refused Mostaq's offer immediately after the coup to send a Bangladeshi team to Pakistan to assist with rescue operations in flood-ravaged regions. However, there was no denying the fact that the Pakistanis were watching developments in Bangladesh carefully and were prepared to do all they could to get a foothold in the country as soon as possible.

Meanwhile, the R&AW felt that in the future, Indian and Soviet Union interests in Bangladesh would be effectively eroded and this might suit the USA. The Americans were already anxious about the growing Russian presence in Bangladesh and the USSR's attempts to penetrate all levels of Bangladesh society and centres of power. Verma said in his secret note:

A more pro-west, pro-Pakistani and proChinese outlook in Bangladesh will create problems which will have ramifications outside the borders of this subcontinent. If Bangladesh becomes a pawn in the clash of superpower interests in the region, this area will tend to develop into one of instability with obvious repercussions on us. In such an environment, the Chinese and the Pakistanis could feel encouraged to enlarge their conspiracies against us. Bhutto had always thought that the presence of East Pakistan close to the areas of instability in India was a matter of great luck

to Pakistan, which should be fully exploited. It is possible that he may think on the same lines when Bangladesh and Pakistan become close to each other once again. The Chinese have also a similar interest. They would not allow themselves to fall behind once they arrive in Bangladesh.

But there was little that India could do at this stage beyond handling the situation diplomatically.